

# Quick start

Five minutes, start to finish.

1

## Install it

You only do this once. It runs without installing anything permanently.

```
uv tool install pixieduster
```

2

## Decide who the persona is

Invent a character, or clone a real voice from writing. Pick one:

```
pixieduster clone -d "a friendly desktop robot with great humor"
pixieduster clone --from ./my-essays
--from takes text files, PDFs, even screenshots of handwriting.
pixieduster clone --repo .
```

3

## Look before you send

Add `--dry-run` to any of those. It shows exactly what would go to Google and sends nothing at all.

```
pixieduster clone -d "a grumpy lighthouse keeper" --dry-run
```

4

## Run it for real

Answer three questions with the arrow keys, set the humour slider, wait about thirty seconds.

5

## You are done

You get `persona.md` - the full voice specification. Paste it into any AI as a system prompt. With `--repo` it writes `AGENTS.md`, which Claude Code and Cursor pick up on their own.

## What you will see

- A gold PixieDuster logo across the top of your terminal.
- A list of what it will send, and what it will cost.
- Three questions, one at a time. Arrow keys to move, enter to pick.
- A slider for how funny the persona should be.
- A gold certificate showing the persona it made.

## The other two commands

```
pixieduster chat
```

Talk to your persona and hear how it sounds.

```
pixieduster diff draft.md
```

Ask whether something you wrote sounds like you.

## If something goes wrong

### It says no API key found

Run `pixieduster config set-key` and paste your key. Once only.

### It says the key is not valid

Something else may be overriding it. Run `pixieduster config show` to see which of the four places your key is coming from.

### It found no writing samples

Nothing to learn from. Either point `--from` at some writing, or skip samples entirely and invent a character with `--describe`.

### It found a possible password

It stops and shows you. Add `--scrub` to blank them out, or look at what it found and decide.

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Your writing is sent to Google to be analysed. Use `--dry-run` to see exactly what would go, before it goes.